



Above *Tarte Tatin* is an “upside-down” apple pie, where the golden-brown caramelized apples sit atop a layer of flaky, buttery pastry

Left The extravagant Château de Chambord, a hunting lodge for François I, is the largest of the Loire châteaux, boasting 440 rooms



Above Lamotte-Beuvron's Hôtel Tatin, where the Tatin sisters cooked up their famous tart, is still going strong today as a hotel and restaurant

Tarte Tatin Festival

The annual *Foire au Pays des la Tarte Tatin* (*tarte Tatin* festival) takes place in mid-September in Lamotte-Beuvron. There are tart-making demonstrations, often by a renowned, Loire-based chef employing only the ingredients used by the revered Tatin sisters. Baking aficionados can enter the *tarte Tatin* contest, and the winner walks away with a handsome trophy. This is, after all, a festival designed for people “wishing to taste, evaluate, and defend the *tarte Tatin*.” It’s a serious, if delicious, business. But individualists beware – any attempts to improve on the original recipe will be treated with the appropriate disdain.

The Best Places to Eat Tarte Tatin

Grand Hôtel du Lion d’Or expensive

Didier Clément, chef at the Michelin-starred Lion d’Or in Romorantin-Lanthenay, is inspired by the produce of the Sologne and driven by the seasons. He’s also a fan of long-forgotten varieties of herbs, spices, and heirloom vegetables and fruits, such as *reine de reinettes* (“king of the pippins”) apples, and he works with gardeners and farmers in the region to grow them for his table. In fall and winter, he showcases his version of “*la tarte des demoiselles Tatin*,” cooking up perfectly caramelized apples on a puff-pastry base that would have the sisters beaming. He admits, however, that he actually prefers to serve his “lighter version” of the apple classic: a millefeuille of *reinette* apples crowned with quince ice cream (an old-fashioned favorite that Clément champions) and frothy caramel. In summer, diners can eat in the flower-filled courtyard of the 16th-century hotel, and in winter they’re ensconced in high-end country comfort in the formal dining room, with its chandeliers and starched white cloths.

69 rue Georges Clemenceau, Romorantin-Lanthenay; open for lunch and dinner Wed–Mon, closed 1–13 Aug, 19–29 Dec and 16 Feb–10 Mar; www.hotel-liondor.fr

Also in the Loire

A visit to sleepy little Lamotte-Beuvron wouldn’t be complete without a pit stop at the **Hôtel Tatin** (www.hotel-Tatin.fr; *moderate*), the alleged birthplace of the tart. It still has the same coal- and wood-burning tiled stove in which the famed sisters baked their tarts. *Reine de reinettes* remains the apple of choice, cut into slices, quarters, or chunks, layered in a special pan, cooked to golden perfection, and served comfortingly warm.

Also in France

Philippe Conticini is an artist when it comes to cakes, tarts, and all the finer, sweeter things in life. His Paris bakery, **La Pâtisserie des Rêves** (www.lapatisserie-des-reves.com; *inexpensive*), is chock-full of his creations, including an irresistible *tarte Tatin*. His rendition has slivers of apple piled high on a square of crispy puff pastry; the pale, almost translucent apple sheets on the bottom rise up the color scale to the caramel-colored beauties on top. The *tarte* is served with a pot of lime-flavored mascarpone.

Around the World

London’s much-lauded **Le Gavroche** (www.le-gavroche.co.uk; *expensive*), founded in 1967 by the Roux brothers, dishes up a delicious *tarte Tatin* that perfectly finishes a top-end French meal. Individual-sized tarts brimming with caramelized apples come with a dollop of Madagascan-vanilla-flavored ice cream.